



WATCH THE INTERVIEW WITH
NETHERLANDS FORWARD
SOSHA BENNINGA

Plenty to like, much to fix

The hockey impressed and the crowds responded, yet **familiar questions** around planning, continuity and professionalism lingered through HIL-W's second season.

Santadeep Dey

santadeep.dey@thehindu.co.in

For a tournament still finding its feet, the four-team Women's Hockey India League moves remarkably fast. So much so that by the time fans begin settling into their seats, it already feels like time to pack up and leave.

Ambition, when rushed, tends to trip over its own stick. Make no mistake, there are no qualms about the hockey itself. **From the opening hooter to the final presentation ceremony, spectators are treated to compelling, end-to-end action.** However, scratch just beneath the surface and the league starts to feel like a work in progress and not a finished product.

The buildup, as with last year, to what is currently billed as the world's only commercial hockey league for women, was not particularly encouraging. The promise of

expanding to six teams this season remained what it had been in 2024: a mere promise.

Matters, in fact, deteriorated further with the defending champion, Navoyam Sports-owned Odisha Warriors, choosing to pull out of the 2025-26 season. **Cracks had begun to show immediately after the conclusion of the league last year, when the team defaulted on salary payments, exposing the lack of robust financial modelling.**

Eventually, Hockey India had to intervene and pay the players from the winners' prize pool, raising uncomfortable questions about revenue security.

"There are at least two other franchises that had delayed payouts until May last year. Many were initially paid only a small percentage of the whole sum. The players were constantly being given assurances

that the teams were having emergency meetings with sponsors. It was a frustrating wait," a source tells *Sportstar*. This is not only highly unusual for a professional league but also a red flag for financial credibility, especially in relatively low-paying women's sports.

Yet, if one were inclined to argue that professional women's sports outfits are not viable commercial enterprises, cricket's Women's Premier League would suggest otherwise. **Five teams, a viewer-friendly format that includes an eliminator-style playoff ahead of the final, and consistent team identities have ensured franchise stability.** Even newer leagues outside India, such as the United States' Women's Elite Rugby of 2025, have consciously adopted multi-city engagement to help develop seasonal narratives.